River Deep Mountain AI

Funding water body health improvements

An accompanying guide to the River Deep Mountain AI funding sources database

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V2.0	Revised funding handbook to accompany updated funding database.	Gosia Druzkowska	GD	11/02/2026

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Executive Summary

Water bodies in the UK are facing unprecedented challenges due to pollution from human activity, which impacts society and the environment. As social awareness of this challenge increases and water regulation puts pressure on organisations to monitor and control sources of water body pollution, the drive for change is accelerating. Advances in Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Machine Learning (ML) make it possible to generate novel analysis into water body health, utilising open data frameworks and connecting the complex factors impacting water bodies on a catchment scale.

The River Deep Mountain AI (RDMAI) programme will deliver proofs-of-concepts demonstrating how AI and ML models can help to enhance and improve water body health. The State of Natural Capital Report for England 2024[1] has evidenced the urgency in using data driven approaches for informing decision making, as asset restoration becomes more challenging over time. The RDMAI programme will provide data driven evidence for informing effective action to tackle water body pollution.

Given the urgency to implement change and address the challenges facing natural capital, including water body health, the Funding Water Body Health Improvements database has been developed to enable actions that will help to improve the health of UK water bodies. As improvements to water body health may require interventions, some of which will have associated capital and maintenance costs, this database has been designed to show the wide range of options available when seeking funding for water body health improvements. Current funding opportunities are included alongside past funding sources, showing where water body health improvement funding can be sourced or the funding bodies to approach.

[1] Lusardi, J., Rice, P., Craven, J., Hinson, C., Bell, F., Morgan, A., Martin, K., Dobson, M., Sunderland, T., Waters, R. (2024). State of Natural Capital Report for England 2024: Risks to nature and why it matters. Natural England Research Report Number NERR137

An introduction to the water body health improvements funding sources database

To enable action that helps improve water body health, the River Deep Mountain AI project has compiled a database of funding sources. Stakeholders are encouraged to use the model outputs from the project to better understand the health of water bodies and where targeted action would be most effective at addressing these challenges. Once a water body health challenge is identified, the funding sources database can be used by stakeholders to identify suitable funding options to address the challenge.

The funding sources database has been complied using a systematic search, further details on this method is provided below, alongside expert knowledge from practitioners who have applied for funding themselves or support others through consultancy. To ensure only reliable, relevant, and accessible funding opportunities were included in the funding sources database, inclusion criteria were developed. Full details of this inclusion criteria are provided below.

The funding sources included apply to a wide range of stakeholders. The sources are suited to individual stakeholders. Alternatively, several funding opportunities are open to consortiums of stakeholders. Stakeholders may choose to apply for funding from several sources, depending on eligibility and the value of the funding required. In this handbook, the stakeholders have been categorised as follows to allow filtering in the database:

- Water companies
- Charities
- Academia
- Industry (e.g. agriculture)
- Local Authorities
- Landowners
- Community Groups
- Not-for-profit
- NGOs

Quick guide

The Funding Water Body Health Improvements database is published as an Excel tool, ensuring it is widely accessible to all stakeholders. A filter tool has been developed to help stakeholders identify potentially relevant funding sources. For example, if the stakeholder is an NGO, the NGO option can be selected, displaying funding options available to NGOs.

The first sheet of the Excel tool has a drop-down menu where the relevant stakeholder can be selected. If this drop-down menu is left blank, all funding sources will be displayed.

Once the stakeholder is selected, the second sheet will update, filtering the potentially relevant funding sources. Each funding source is accompanied by a brief description and has information regarding the funding amount, the application process, and who to contact for further information.

Users can return to the first sheet to update the selected stakeholder; the tool will then return other funding options.

Funding sources to improve water body health

The systematic search returned 116 funding sources. Although application deadlines may reduce the number of funding opportunities available at any one time, stakeholders looking to improve water body health have a broad range of options.

Funding amounts of up to £10,000,000 were identified, although most funds were more modest or allowed for specific capital costs (e.g. per metre of stock fencing). Typically, larger grants were available from Lottery Funding. All funding sources had eligibility criteria, and these vary widely. Given the difference in the criteria, an application reused with another funder may be unsuccessful without considerable revisions. When applying, stakeholders should review the guidance from the specific funding source to ensure the eligibility criteria have been met.

The systematic search found a modest bias towards funding opportunities aimed at Industry, particularly the agricultural sector. The fewest number of opportunities are available to water companies. Table 2 provides a summary of the funding options available for each stakeholder.

Table 1 – The number of opportunities available for each stakeholder type.

Stakeholder	Number of funding opportunities available
Water companies	12
Charities	78
Academia	13
Industry (e.g. agriculture)	69
Local Authorities	26
Landowners	72
Community Groups	78
Not-for-profit	76
NGOs	75

Alternative funding sources

Stakeholders could also consider alternative funding sources, which differ from more traditional grant-based funding.

Working with business

Organisations looking to improve water body health can partner with businesses to fund water body health improvements. Collaborative action between eNGOs and business can enable action that addresses water body health challenges and works towards corporate sustainability targets by funding projects with social and environmental benefits.

An example of a business funding water body health improvements is the partnership between Amazon Web Services, The Rivers Trust and Action for the River Kennet. The organisations are addressing water scarcity and declining water quality in the River Thames basin by building two wetlands that will recharge groundwater and improve water quality by treating polluted runoff from farms and roads. The new wetlands provide a community resource in addition to catchment-scale water quality improvements.

Nature markets

Nature markets create opportunities to enhance water body health by establishing a structured system for trading nature-based units, which represent quantifiable environmental benefits. This market framework allows stakeholders, such as suppliers, to generate and sell units from projects like river restoration, directly linking investments with specific environmental outcomes.

A key element of nature markets is the focus on high-integrity units that must be additional, meaning they represent environmental improvements beyond what

would occur under typical conditions. For water bodies, this could include measures such as nutrient reduction in catchment areas or habitat restoration, leading to improved water quality, biodiversity, and flood resilience. By trading these units, nature markets incentivise and fund these water-enhancing interventions, addressing the funding gap for ecosystem restoration.

Furthermore, the structure of these markets promotes transparency and accountability by requiring robust quantification of the baseline environment, as well as validation and verification of environmental outcomes. This assurance helps attract investors looking for credible, measurable impacts on water body health, thus providing sustained funding for continuous improvements and ongoing maintenance of water ecosystems.

An example of nature markets improving water body health is the Upper Tana-Nairobi Water Fund in Kenya. A water fund was established through collaboration between The Nature Conservancy (TNC), the Nairobi City Water and Sewerage Company, the Kenya Electricity Generating Company, and various local partners. Water funds are founded on the principle that it is cheaper to *prevent* water problems at the source than it is to address them further downstream. Public and private donors and major water consumers downstream contribute to the water fund to support upstream water and soil conservation measures, resulting in improved water quality and supply. By investing in sustainable land management practices, the fund supports 15,000 farmers in the watershed to reduce soil erosion and sediment runoff, which has significantly improved water quality in the Tana River.

Water company funding

Water companies can be a source of funding for water body health improvements, and several of these opportunities were identified in the systematic search. In England, the Water Industry National Environment Programme (WINEP) is the programme of work that water companies are required to do to fulfil their obligations arising from environmental legislation and UK government policy. Water companies help fund improvements in water body health to meet their obligations under the WINEP and similar legislation, and could be considered as a potential funding source when stakeholders are seeking funding.

Methodology: Systematic search

Search terms

A systematic search methodology was used to identify funding sources as comprehensively as possible. The web search used Boolean operators to search for a water body challenge and an accompanying funding phrase; these are detailed in Table 2. All combinations of water body challenge and funding source were used, with the results stored in a database prior to screening. Details of the screening process are provided below.

Table 2 - Search terms used in the systematic web search.

Water body challenge	Funding
Acidification	Action
Agricultural Pollution	Aid
Agricultural runoff	Capital Grants
Algal blooms	Catchment Sensitive Farming
Aquatic ecosystems	Charitable support
Aquifer recharge	Financial Incentives
Atmospheric Deposition	Financial support
Bacteria and pathogens	Financing
Bathing water quality	Fund
Biodiversity	Funding
Catchment management	Grant
Climate change	Green investment
Coastal health	Innovation
Combined Sewer Overflows	Nature markets
Constructed wetlands	Nutrient trading
Cover crops	Partnership
Crop rotation	Payments
Drinking water protection	Philanthropic support
Erosion control	Programme
Eutrophication	Scheme
Excessive abstraction	Stewardship
Faecal Indicator Organisms (FIOs)	Subsidy
Fish population	
Flash flooding	
Floodplain	
Freshwater ecosystems	
Green infrastructure	
Groundwater quality	
Habitat Degradation	
Heavy metals	

Water body challenge	Funding
Household chemicals	
Hydrocarbons	
Hydrological restoration	
Hypoxia	
Industrial pollution/pollutants	
Integrated Pest Management (IPM)	
Invasive Species	
Irrigation	
Lake* quality	
Land Use Changes	
Litter and debris	
Livestock fencing	
Low flow rates	
Marine habitat protection	
Marine water quality	
Metaldehydes	
Microplastics	
Mining and Resource Extraction runoff	
Natural flood management	
Nitrates	
Nutrient levels in water	
Nutrient management regulations	
Oil and grease	
Organic Farming	
Pathway	
Pesticides	
pH	
Pharmaceuticals	
Phosphates	
Phosphorous	
Pollution control measures	
Precision farming	
Receptor	
Reforestation	
Riparian buffer	
River pollution	
River restoration	
River* health	
River* improvement	
Riverbank restoration	
Salinisation	
Sea-level rise	

Water body challenge	Funding
Sediment	
Sediment control	
Sewage	
Shellfish water quality	
Source	
Stormwater management	
Stormwater management systems	
Surface water quality	
Sustainable fisheries	
Sustainable Urban Drainage Systems	
Thermal pollution	
Untreated sewage	
Urban drainage policy	
Urban runoff	
Wastewater treatment plants	
Water body health	
Water clarity	
Water conservation	
Water contamination	
Water Framework Directive	
Water pollution indicators	
Water pollution prevention	
Water quality	
Water recycling	
Water resource management	
Water reuse	
Wetland ecosystems	
Wetland restoration	

* Other water body types were included, e.g. lake, stream, loch

Criteria for inclusion and screening of funding sources

Purpose

Inclusion criteria were prepared to determine which funding sources were included in the database. These inclusion criteria ensure that only reliable and relevant sources are considered, and that they have accessible application processes. By defining these criteria, the database becomes a practical resource that meets the diverse needs of various stakeholders.

Inclusion criteria

Relevance to water body health

Funding sources must accept applications for projects that will improve or restore the health of water bodies. For example, funding may target environmental sustainability, biodiversity, water quality, or ecosystem restoration efforts.
Examples of these projects include:

- River restoration and habitat creation.
- Pollution reduction in water bodies.
- Biodiversity projects aimed at water ecosystems.

Geographical coverage

The funding sources must be available in the UK. However, the funding source can be local, national, or international, and the applicability will depend on the individual project's scope.
For a funding source to be included, the funder must have clearly defined geographic boundaries for funding (e.g., UK, EU, Global), and if relevant, funders must specify the specific regions where the funding is applicable, for example, a specific catchment or county.

Funding amount

Funding sources should ideally state the amount of money that can be applied for, enabling stakeholders to scope their projects effectively and establish if the funding source is appropriate. Both small-scale and large-scale funds were included.

Eligibility requirements

Funding sources should clearly define the types of organisations or individuals that are eligible to apply. Sources will be excluded if the eligibility requirements are unclear, or the process is considered prohibitively difficult to meet for most stakeholders. The funding source database includes a filter so specific stakeholders can see the funding options relevant to them.

Conditions and restrictions

Specific conditions or restrictions that apply to the use of funds must be disclosed. This ensures transparency for applicants, allowing them to determine whether the funding is suitable for their project. Only funding sources that clearly list any terms and conditions or restrictions will be included. Examples of restrictions include funds that are restricted to specific project types (e.g., river health only) or projects requiring a certain level of co-funding or match-funding.

Application process and deadlines

The application process must be clearly defined and feasible for potential applicants. Therefore, funding sources that share the following were included:

- Detailed steps for applying (e.g., forms, documentation, deadlines).

- The specific information required during the application, such as project proposals and budgets.

Other inclusion criteria

The following inclusion criteria were also applied:

- Funding sources were included providing sufficient contact information was given.
- The application process needed to be clear and available from the outset.
- Sources were included providing there was transparency and accountability in how the funds are allocated. If the award criteria were unclear, then the funding source was excluded.

Screening process

During the search process steps were taken to ensure funding sources were aligned with the above inclusion criteria. Each source underwent an initial screening, where it was assessed based on its title for relevance. If of relevance, or potential relevance, the funding source was evaluated against the inclusion criteria above.
After passing the screening, key information regarding the funding was recorded in the database. The database records parameters including: a description, the geographical coverage, funding value, eligibility, specific conditions and information regarding the application process.

Maintenance and updates

The funding source database was reviewed and updated in January 2026. While there are no plans for ongoing updates, the database can be used as a resource to understand current and past funding options.